an exciting evening for him. The ambulance man must have stepped on it for us: we had to get across Manchester to the Royal Infirmary in Whalley Range and seemed to do the trip in about five minutes flat.

I had my x-ray almost as soon as we got to the hospital. Victoria went through to look at the results with Doctor Noble and she came out to tell me what they'd seen.

'The bad news is it's broken. The good news is that, if everything goes well, you should be fine for the World Cup.'

The first bit was no surprise. The second bit was what I'd been waiting and hoping to hear since the moment I'd been clattered by Duscher.

Victoria left it to Doctor Noble to explain the injury. I'd fractured the second metatarsal, a tiny bone between the toe and the rest of the foot, which usually has enough flesh around it to keep it out of harm's way. It's very rare to damage it, apparently. But try telling Gary Neville or Danny Murphy that: they both missed the World Cup because of the same injury. The doctor confirmed that he thought I'd have just enough time to recover. I hung onto that over the next few weeks, even when I had my doubts about being ready: never mind the bone healing, I knew I needed to be match-fit for England as well.

The following morning, I couldn't believe what we woke up to. What was my foot doing on the front page of the papers? Sven was one of the first people to ring me, although it may have been less about: 'Are you all right?' and more about: 'Are you going to be fit?' It was good to hear from him. He told me that, whether I was fit to play or not, he'd want me to come out and be involved at the World Cup. Sven's support then, and later, made a real difference to me. At the hospital, they'd put my foot in a cast. Dwight Yorke picked me up in his car and took me in to training at Carrington. The United medical team took the plaster off and replaced it with a thing called an air cast, a sort of inflatable boot. When it was pumped full of air, it protected my foot in the same way the plaster cast would. But I could release a valve and take this thing off in order to work on my ankle and my leg. Even after a day or two in plaster, my calf and ankle had shrunk. The air cast was a way of trying to make sure I wouldn't suffer any more muscle wasting than was unavoidable. After I'd done my physiotherapy, I could re-inflate the blow-up boot again and hobble away on crutches. It was a couple of days later that I sat down with the doctors and talked through what I needed to do to give myself my best chance of being ready: